

III

Esther

The orphan who became queen of Persia and risked her life to save her people, "for such a time as this."

Esther was a Jewish orphan in the Persian capital of Shushan, raised by her cousin Mordecai. Chosen as queen by King Ahasuerus, she kept her Jewish identity secret. Then the king's chief official, Haman, won a decree to wipe out every Jew in the empire. Though going uninvited could mean death, after fasting she went in, won his favour, and at two banquets exposed Haman's plot. Her people were saved, and Purim still remembers it. The book never names God, yet his hand seems behind every turn.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew Hadassah, "myrtle"; Esther, perhaps "star" (Esther 2:7)
Family	Daughter of Abihail; raised by her cousin Mordecai (Esther 2:7, 15)
Husband	Ahasuerus, usually identified with Xerxes I (486–465 BC)
Became queen	c. 479 BC, in the king's seventh year (Esther 2:16–17)
Home	Shushan (Susa), the Persian royal city
Key people	Mordecai, Ahasuerus, Haman, Hegai, Hatach, Vashti
Legacy	The feast of Purim (Esther 9:26–32)
New Testament	Not named; the book is not quoted

"For if thou altogether holdest thy peace at this time, then shall there enlargement and deliverance arise to the Jews from another place ... and who knoweth whether thou art come to the kingdom for such a time as this?"

Esther 4:14, KJV

The life of Esther

Dates approximate (BC), counted from Xerxes I; the Greek version calls the king Artaxerxes.

- c. 483 BC

3rd year

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The queen is deposed

Queen Vashti refuses the king's summons, and his advisers urge him to give her place to another. *Esther 1:3, 10-19*
- Before she became queen

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Brought to the palace

Esther is gathered with other young women. Hegai favours her, and on Mordecai's advice she hides her people. *Esther 2:7-11*
- c. 479 BC

7th year, 10th month

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Crowned queen

After twelve months of preparation she goes to the king, who loves her above all and crowns her. *Esther 2:12-18*
- c. 479-474 BC

As queen

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A plot uncovered

Esther reports, in Mordecai's name, a plot by two doorkeepers to kill the king. *Esther 2:19-23*
- c. 474 BC

12th year, 1st month

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A decree of death

Haman obtains a decree against the Jews. Esther calls a three-day fast: "if I perish, I perish." *Esther 3:7-4:17*
- Three days later

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Two banquets

The king holds out his sceptre to her. At her second banquet she names "this wicked Haman," and he is hanged. *Esther 5:1-8; 7:1-10*
- c. 474-473 BC

3rd to 12th months

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Deliverance and Purim

Esther pleads for a second decree; the Jews defend themselves, and Purim is confirmed. *Esther 8:3-17; 9:1-32*

Group notes

Key activities

The book of Esther never mentions God, prayer or the temple. Yet a string of "coincidences," from a sleepless king to perfectly timed banquets, turns the plot upside down. Many readers see here God's hidden care for his people.

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- I Won favour in a hard place.** Esther "obtained favour in the sight of all them that looked upon her," from Hegai to the king. *Esther 2:9, 15, 17*

 - 2 Honoured the man who raised her.** Even as queen, she still followed Mordecai's advice, "like as when she was brought up with him." *Esther 2:10, 20*

 - 3 Saved the king's life.** She passed on Mordecai's warning of an assassination plot and gave him the credit. *Esther 2:21-23*

 - 4 Sought the facts.** When Mordecai put on sackcloth, she sent Hatach, the attendant the king had given her, to learn exactly what was wrong. *Esther 4:4-9*

 - 5 Named the risk honestly.** She told Mordecai that anyone who came to the king uncalled could be put to death. *Esther 4:10-11*

 - 6 Called a fast.** She asked the Jews of Shushan to fast three days, and she and her maids fasted too. *Esther 4:15-16*

 - 7 Went in uninvited.** She put on her royal robes and stood in the inner court, and the king held out his sceptre. *Esther 5:1-3*

 - 8 Waited for the right moment.** Rather than blurt out her request, she hosted two banquets and let the king's curiosity grow. *Esther 5:4-8; 7:1-2*

 - 9 Spoke up for her people.** "Let my life be given me at my petition, and my people at my request." *Esther 7:3-6*

 - 10 Pleaded with tears.** Even after Haman's death, she fell at the king's feet: "how can I endure to see the evil that shall come unto my people?" *Esther 8:3-6*

 - II Fixed Purim in writing.** With Mordecai she wrote "with all authority" to confirm the feast for every generation. *Esther 9:29-32*

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Esther. Tradition: Greek additions (in the Apocrypha) add prayers and name God; a traditional tomb stands in Hamadan, Iran.

Old Testament

Esther 1–10	The only book that tells her story
Ezra 4:6	"Ahasuerus," probably the same king as her husband
Esther 9:26–32	"The decree of Esther" confirms Purim
Echo: Genesis 41:37–45; Daniel 2:48	Like Joseph and Daniel, serving in a foreign court
Echo: Exodus 17:14–16; 1 Samuel 15:8	Haman the Agagite recalls the war with Amalek

New Testament

Echo: Mark 6:23	Herod's "half of my kingdom" echoes Esther 5:3
Echo: Hebrews 4:16	Believers may "come boldly unto the throne of grace"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What reasons did Mordecai give Esther for going to the king (Esther 4:13–14)?
2. *Understand:* God is never named in Esther. How can we still see him at work in the story?
3. *Apply:* Esther found herself in a position she did not choose. Where has God placed you "for such a time as this"?
4. *Apply:* Esther prepared with fasting and patience before she spoke. Is there a hard conversation you need to prepare for this week? How will you get ready?